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ISSUE 3 2021

Homeschooling

LIVING & LEARNING – TOGETHER

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+ homeschool
survival tips

My story:
What teens
really want

Why
teamwork
matters

Important SANHSA
legislation update!

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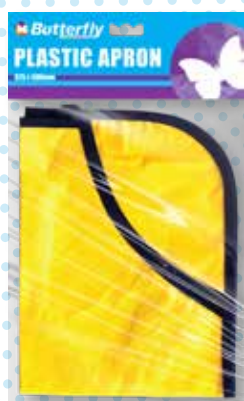
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25S
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Bostik
Glitter Glue
Assorted 6

64⁹⁰

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Your **feedback is essential** in helping us put together a magazine which delivers on-point content relevant to your homeschooling experiences and support needs and **helps you navigate** your child/ children's education with ease and confidence.

You are the **core** of the publication, so let's live and learn together.

Email our editor, Shelagh Foster, at: shelagh@isikhova.co.za.





Ed's note

I'm increasingly aware of the differences in homeschooling styles: the traditional curriculum families, the 'let's see how it goes', the 'unschoolers'. Agreeing about many things but sometimes poles apart. And this is good, because you are the pioneers, the innovators.

These times will go down in history. Our children will learn that education is as much about living a true and rich life as about a Bachelor's pass. Both these are of value, so where do we strike the balance and take responsibility as home educators?

SAH strives for reflecting that balance between schooling and learning. Learning is tactile, bookish and experiential. It's about creating a love of knowledge, being excited about finding stuff out and getting it wrong so we can get it right. Learning is education.

The *SAH* teams commit to supporting you in getting it right, so let's stay strong together, dear readers. Difference is beautiful.

Shelagh

Editor

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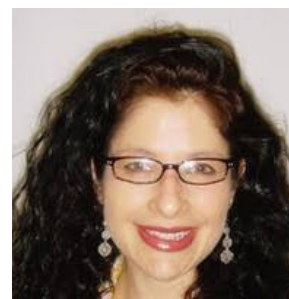
Marian is a remedial therapist and a mom with a special interest in early reading development and teaching readers from ages five to nine online and in person. In addition to reading lessons through Raising Readers, she offers homeschooling parent talks, workshops and multi-sensory literacy kits to help you raise your child to read.

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Team power

What is 'social fluency' and why do we all crave – and need – to be a part of something greater than ourselves?

Brett Garner investigates

Growing up, I was fed a disproportionately large dose of Robinsonade. The dog-eared pages of my large, vividly illustrated copies of *Robinson Crusoe*, *Treasure Island* and *The Swiss Family Robinson* regularly fanned the sails of my imagination.

A week before the start of my Grade 8 year, my mother added another book to my meagre library – a copy of William Golding's *Lord of the Flies*. 'This is about high school,' was all she said. I was terrified.

That same sense of dread struck me some years back when I stumbled upon the following while doing background research on accommodating anxious learners in the mainstream classroom. Writing for a small Los Angeles-based preschool, the unnamed writer stated that 'missing preschool makes homeschoolers prone to anxiety, loneliness and even neurosis'.

There isn't much definitive data comparing the social fluency of homeschooled children with those in mainstream schools, but





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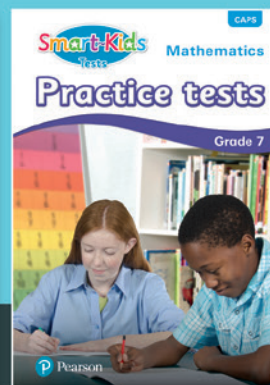
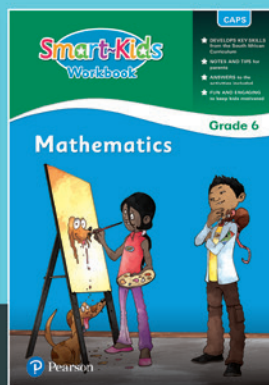
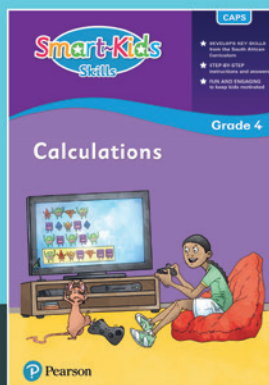
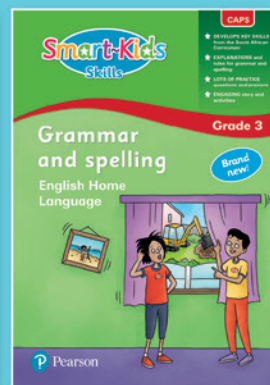
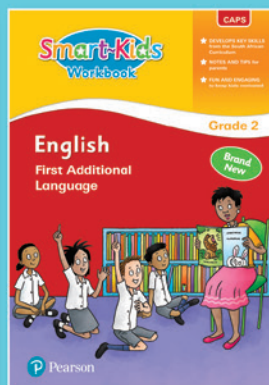
Children love learning with Smart-Kids.

Smart-Kids is a range of colourful activity books that support the CAPS curriculum and provide additional support for Grades R to 7.

The books include answers, notes and tips for parents and they're such fun that you won't have to nag your children to do extra practice at home.

Available in Afrikaans as **Slimkoppe**.

Free worksheets at www.smart-kids.com



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anecdotal evidence suggests that the author's statement is far from the truth.

Having said that, the relatively small group size that most homeschooled children are exposed to means that parents need to make an overt effort to nurture their children's ability to negotiate a variety of different social situations, develop and maintain strong relationships, and work well with others in varying contexts.

While the need seems intuitively obvious, it bears framing. Exposing children to a variety of people and situations allows them to learn that context often defines whether a particular behaviour or approach is appropriate or inappropriate. Children need to interact with others to learn when to stand their

ground and when to seek help from others. Most importantly, perhaps, children need to learn that there's a thin line between obedience and conformity. When all a child has to fall back on are 'the rules', standing his or her ground confidently is made all the more difficult.

What, then, can homeschoolers do to develop social fluency?

The most effective method is personal example. Exposing children to even-tempered and open-minded people models social competence. Parents, family members, a sports coach or the local SPCA volunteer co-ordinator can all serve as role models.

Educational activities and outings, especially with others, help children expand their horizons and generally challenge them to consider the perceptions and perspectives of those in the group. From baking a cake as a group to an overnight camping trip, the opportunities are endless, if tackled intentionally.



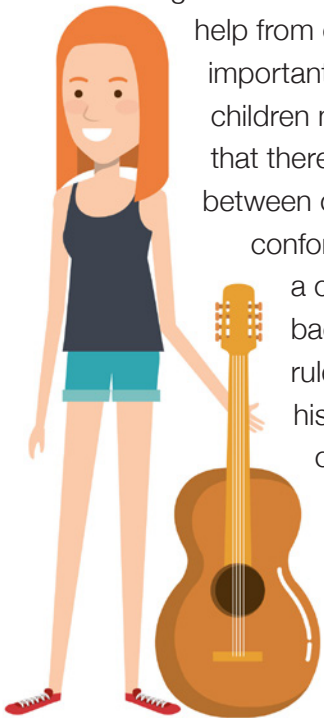
Playing a team sport or performing music in a group is a proven way of allowing leaders, non-conformists and everyone in between to learn to interact with others and add value to the whole.

Extramurals

Fortunately, there are now more opportunities for this interaction – whether it be team sports or collaborating on a science project. The St Martin's



‘Children need to interact with others to learn when to stand their ground and when to seek help from others.’



Homeschoolers' Enrichment Programme (in Rosettenville, Johannesburg) is one example of a traditional school reaching out to homeschoolers, offering exciting activities to enhance the child's learning experience in a wide range of contexts.

These include sport (and access to the school's sports facilities for additional training); science and biology practicals; theatre visits and eisteddfods (lockdown levels allowing); academic outings;

'The most effective method is personal example.'



prep school art, piano and guitar lessons. It's quite a feast of wonderful things to do and learn.

St Martin's headmaster Thomas Hagspihl sums it up: 'Having social interaction on a sports field and being part of a team is an important aspect of a young child's – and, indeed, any teenager's – social development. It's well known that being part of a team teaches children resilience, patience and discipline. The "hidden curriculum" is a hugely important part of what happens at this school – in some cases, dare I say, more important than differential equations, continental drift and chemical titrations.'



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Work from home, school at home

Working from home can be lovely. Homeschooling can be lovely. Doing both is enough to fry even the most organised and patient parent's brain. Try these tips for keeping it together

1 Have a schedule. Sit down with your family and discuss what needs to be achieved in a week and how you're going to help each other do that. Then draw up a list of what needs to be done and when. Include any work deadlines, schoolwork assignments and extramural activities. If need be, set reminders on your phone and/or computer so nothing slips through the cracks.

2 Be flexible within that schedule. Workloads and commitments can change with the wind.

Children get sick. Parents get sick. This isn't the time to panic, but rather to sit down and figure out how you're going to adapt your existing schedule to suit the circumstances. If you all decide to take the day off, fine – but be sure to allocate time elsewhere for the missed tasks.



3 Designate spaces and (mostly) stick to them.

Old lore dictates that you shouldn't have your workspace in the bedroom. That can get tricky if your 'spare' space is now designated to homeschooling, so do what works best for you and your family. Make sure you have enough designated workspace, plenty of hidden storage and lots of shelves for work and study books and supplies.

4 Ease into work mode. Many work-from-home-homeschooling parents have figured out that getting up an hour earlier than their children and easing into the day, rather than crashing into it, is the best way to maintain sanity. Developing morning habits such as quiet time, email-checking, breakfast-setting – and uninterrupted showers! – can help you feel in charge of the day.

5 Have a few basic rules regarding quiet time, taking breaks, outdoor time, respecting work calls/Zoom and respecting spaces. If you involve your children in making those rules, they'll be more likely to stick to them.



6 If you can afford it, get help/assistance with younger children – even if it means paying a local teenager to read or play with them a few hours a week. Even the closest of families need a breather every now and then.



7 Don't try to do it all yourself. Unfortunately, it's still common for the 'go-out-to-work' parent to assume that the 'work-from-home' parent has plenty of time to do the housework, homeschool and do their job. This, of course, is nonsense, so be prepared to have a difficult conversation if your workload's getting out of hand.

8 Be upfront with your employer/clients. Create realistic expectations regarding deliverables and timelines and try to be realistic about what you can and can't manage. It's not easy saying 'no' to work, but you'll crash and burn if you take on more than you can handle.

9 Have a weekly family meeting to discuss what does and doesn't work. Amend accordingly. Keep it fun and let everyone have their say.



10 Have at least one completely work-free day a week. No sneaking a peek at your inbox or rechecking yesterday's work. Just be together as a family. And, if you can, arrange for someone to look after your children once a week so you can have some of that elusive 'me-time'. Good luck!



New ADvTECH school offering set to revolutionise online education

Opening its virtual doors to learners from Grade R to Grade 9, from January 2021, ADvTECH's new online offering, Evolve Online School (Evolve), will change the face of online schooling in South Africa.

'In this rapidly changing society, the one-size-fits-all method of teaching no longer makes any sense,' says principal Colin Northmore. 'Evolve starts by answering the question: how can we make learning an adventure for each child?'

Evolve combines a user-experience focus with a trendsetting curriculum mapping system, developed at MIT, to personalise each child's learning experience. Using the latest research, each child's learning journey will be designed based on exclusive subject and skill maps.

Students will be placed within subjects according to their abilities, letting them progress faster where they're gifted and work at a more deliberate pace to master content they find more challenging. The result is that each student's learning experience is tailored to their specific needs and they're encouraged to grow at a pace that suits their ability and enthusiasm.

'There'll be a strong focus on foundational, social and emotional learning skills. Our team of life coaches will focus exclusively on these skills. Our children are growing up in a world very different from the one in which



we grew up. Things that we, as adults, deal with and take in our stride, they're already facing at a very young age. Our life coaches will play a very important role in teaching students how to deal with issues such as stress and anxiety, and help them develop coping mechanisms, resilience and a growth mindset,' adds Northmore.

Evolve will make use of the following:

- **Diagnostic testing** to determine the exact level of proficiency of a student before

placement and during the educational journey.

- **Asynchronous learning** so that learners can move through content at their own pace and according to their own proficiency. Students will also have direct access to their teachers, who'll facilitate extra activation classes.
- **Synchronous learning**, where our students will also be able to attend live interactive classes, making this a true online school.
- **Socialisation opportunities** with academies, studios and day camps monthly so that students can meet other 'Evolvers' and get green time to balance their screen time.

Now enrolling for 2021.

The school will cater for Grades R-9 from January 2021. Grades 10-12 will be phased in from 2022. ADvTECH is Africa's largest private education provider. Its schools division includes iconic brands such as Crawford Schools, Trinityhouse and Abbotts.

Visit: www.evolveonline.co.za for more information or email: info@evolveonline.co.za.



Daniella Kearney was taken out of the public school system at age 12 and is currently being homeschooled by her mom. She plans on becoming a teacher or pursuing her love for writing when her schooling ends. This is her take on what it means to be a teen

Being a teenager is difficult. For most of us, 'lonely' is the only word we can use to describe ourselves. In a world where 'being yourself' is revered, teenagers are in constant conflict trying to figure that out. We're told we need good guidance, but aren't told where to find it. We're told we need virtue, but when we look around us, we see only destruction. We're told to respect ourselves and the people

around us, but aren't respected enough to know how.

Is it any wonder we're the miscreants we are?

The teenage years are the foundation for the rest of our lives. In five years, we must become our own person, figure out who we want to be, get to university, have a romantic relationship, have a job of some sort – and somehow make time to be a child. In a way, it's a

miracle some of us manage to get by, but most of us don't leave our teenage years unscathed. Without guidance, we're left to fend entirely for ourselves, so our dear friend social media becomes the window through which we view life.

When someone says 'teenagers', the very next thought is always 'sex-driven, moody nuisances'. That's become our label. Sex has become our defining characteristic. It's engraved on our brains by films, books and other platforms that sex is what teenagers amount to. Again and again, we're told our values are formed in our sex lives. So, of course, it becomes a self-

centred obsession with the youth of today. An act that was once sacred between a married couple is now given away without thought for the sake of brownie points with the mates. The same goes for drugs and booze. Teenagers are trying to find their identities in a constant ‘damned if you do, damned if you don’t’ situation. Where do we find the guidance we’re so often told to seek?

As long as parents and teachers remain absent in the lives of their children, teenagers will seek knowledge in places where wisdom can’t be found. The knowledge we’ll base our lives upon will come from our peers and various social media platforms. All unprotected environments. The media pushes this idea that every individual is important and, yes, that’s true –

but teenagers have come to believe that this means they’re deserving of more. We’ve come to crave attention in unhealthy ways. To always expect people to give us what we deserve. Is this the world we want for our children? A society of self-centred, hypocritical clones?

In order to heal what’s been broken in the lives of teenagers, we must seek out the root of the issue. Teenagers desire to know they’re in a world that wants them. We wish to have



our opinions matter. We wish to be free to make choices. We want to ask questions that will receive answers. We want a safe environment to express ourselves and to learn. We want guidance from people who care about us. We want to make our choices without being damned for making the wrong ones.

We need to know we’re important enough to have self-respect. Our self-worth shouldn’t be defined by the enormity of our sex lives or the amount of drugs we take. Nor should it be defined by the quality of our academics, or our physical capabilities.

Every individual should be guided to love his/her own self. We should find ourselves through learning the difference between right and wrong and in standing up for what we know to be right. ‘Normal’ isn’t something a teenager should strive to be. So, let’s not be normal. Let’s think with our own minds, learn how to take criticism and use it to our benefit. Let’s learn more and love more. Let’s have a heart for the people around us, because in helping others, we learn to make sacrifices – and in making those sacrifices, we learn what happiness is. That’s the kind of future this broken world is longing for. A future where teenagers give, give freely with open hearts.



‘Teenagers are trying to find their identities in a constant “damned if you do, damned if you don’t” situation.’





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Phonics: What it is and how to teach it

English is often thought of as a language with many spelling exceptions, but did you know that only a small percentage of English words have irregular spellings and letter-sound relationships? **Marian Bailey** explains

Nearly all English words can be read by applying knowledge of letter-sound relationships (phonics) and blending sounds together to form a whole word. Being able to decode words effortlessly means a child can focus their attention on comprehending what they read. Consider this: 'You can decode something you don't know the meaning of, but you can't ever know the meaning of something

you can't decode.' – Pam Snow, professor of cognitive psychology in the School of Education.

We teach children phonics to help them learn the alphabetic principle. That is that letters represent the sounds of spoken language and that there's an organised and predictable relationship between written letters and spoken sounds. Phonics instruction should be structured and explicit, as well as multi-sensory. When teaching phonics, one doesn't assume a

child already knows. Rather teach everything in an organised way that reviews and builds on phonic knowledge.

A helpful starting point is to get to know the terminology, like grapheme, phoneme, digraph and blends, to understand phonics. (Email: marian@raisingreaders.co.za for a free print-out.)

We know the alphabet is made up of consonants and vowels, but in the beginning, your child

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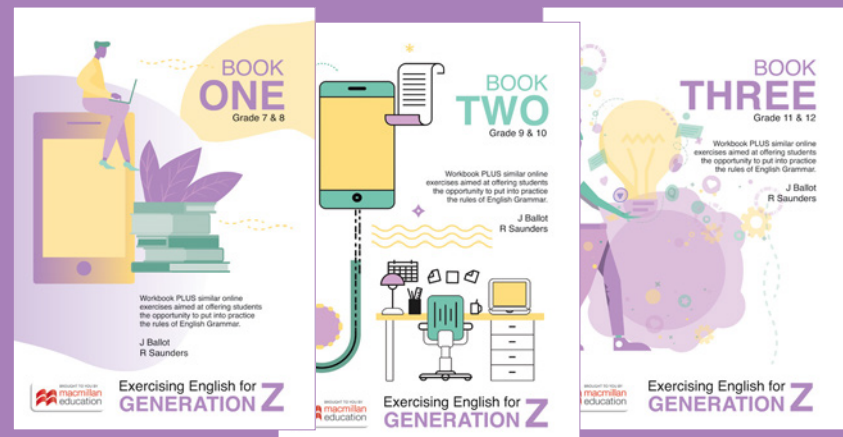
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doesn't understand this and needs to be explicitly taught. There are three types of consonant sounds: continuous sounds (m s f l r n v z), clip sounds (b c d g p t k j) and tricky sounds (h w y x). When teaching consonant sounds, start with the continuous sounds, as these are easier to pronounce. It's important to note that when pronouncing sounds, you *shouldn't* add a vowel sound after the consonant sound. Say /b/, not /bu/. This results in confusion and spelling errors.

The short vowels sound almost alike and as a result, emerging readers need daily short vowel practice. Use key words, visual clues and gestures to remind the child of the difference. Don't move on from short vowels too quickly, as they're key to reading.

Below are three activities you can do every reading lesson to practise phonics. Remember, reading is a



speech-to-print activity, so these drills should be done after some phonemic awareness activities. Drills aren't tests, but activities to improve decoding and encoding skills.

The **VISUAL DRILL** can be described as 'waking up your eyes'.



How to do it: Show a child a sound card and have them say the sound of the letter(s). Please note that it's important to practise sounds your child has learnt, as this is a form of review and assessing which sounds your child has learnt and which ones still need further practice. Visual drills help improve reading.

The **AUDITORY DRILL** can be described as 'waking up your ears'.

How to do it: The adult says a sound to the child, who writes

down the corresponding letter(s). For example, the parent says: 'Write down all the ways you can spell /c/ sound.'

The child will write as many as they've learnt (c, k, -ck). Again, it's important to practise sounds your child has learnt as a review and

use a writing-friendly format, such as a whiteboard. Auditory drills help improve spelling.

The **BLENDING DRILL**

How to do it: Use a blending board and sound cards to practise new and reviewed phonics. Blending drills improve decoding and reading real and nonsense words. Nonsense words are an important part of the decoding and blending process, as many nonsense words are part of multi-syllable words. If an emerging



reader can read 'cat', they can read 'hotdog'. After reading the word, a child can give a thumbs up if it's a real word and a thumbs down if it's a nonsense word.

Raising Readers (www.raisingreaders.co.za) sells blending boards and sound cards and runs parent workshops on this topic. For more information, email: marian@raisingreaders.co.za.

When it comes to reading practice, choose decodable texts or sentences with sound patterns your child has learnt and is learning. This builds fluency and confidence. Giving a child books or sentences with sound patterns they haven't yet learnt only leads to frustration.

Finally, a key element to teaching phonics is to use multi-sensory (visual – auditory – kinaesthetic) methods. For example, if a child is struggling with a particular phonic pattern (eg the sound of '-tch', which we find at the end of short words with a short vowel), let them trace in salt/sand/shaving cream the '-tch' pattern as they're

looking at the '-tch' sound card and saying 't c h says /tch'. This is beneficial for *all* learners, but is highly effective for children with reading challenges.

There are many examples of multi-sensory methods, but here are a few of my favourites:



'Giving a child books or sentences with sound patterns they haven't yet learnt only leads to frustration.'

For decoding

Use manipulatives like counters to sound out words when reading or spelling, sliding up one counter for one sound pattern.

Use the arm-tapping method – sound out a word, tapping each sound down the arm (the word 'slip' has four sounds – /s/ - /l/ - /i/ - /p/ – so the child counts four taps down their arm).

Finger-tap out sounds in a word. One finger is one sound (the word

'chip' has three sounds – /ch/ - /i/ - /p/ – so the child counts out three fingers when reading or spelling).

For spelling

Table-writing and sky-writing – the child uses their first two fingers to 'write' out the sounds in a word on the table or in the sky. No pencil needed!

What about 'sight words'? Linking speech sounds to print using explicit and multi-sensory methods builds orthographic mapping. No more memorising words. Instruction must go from speech to print to form connections that stick and can be retrieved quickly when reading and spelling – so, in fact, all words become sight words. (*More on this in the next article.*)

Remember, decoding is the key to reading. Teaching a child to guess words based on the beginning sound or look at the picture isn't helpful when learning how to read. Each sound pattern needs to be explicitly taught to yield strong readers and spellers.

- *If your child is struggling to learn to read or you'd like support, email: marian@raisingreaders.co.za for one-to-one reading lessons that use a structured, explicit and multi-sensory approach, parent workshops that show you how to use the structured literacy approach and literacy products that support this approach.*



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Walk the walk

‘There’s something about the rhythm of putting one foot in front of the other that does something really good to your brain,’ observed UK TV presenter Kate Humble in a recent article in *The Guardian*. She’s right

Neuropeakpro.com states: ‘Maintaining even a moderate pace increases our heart rate and causes us to breathe deeper. Those deep breaths help more oxygen get into the bloodstream. With the heart pumping faster, our circulation increases and more oxygen gets to the brain.’

‘The researchers [also] found that the impact from hitting our feet on the ground while walking sends a hydraulic wave upwards through our bodies. This wave is actually strong enough to send blood back up through our arteries, increasing blood flow to the brain.’

What this means for you and your children is clearer thinking, better memory, more creativity and greater happiness. So there’s no good reason not to make walking part of your everyday activities. Why not try these five fun ways of mixing it up?

1

Go for a nature walk. Decide upfront what you want to observe (trees, birds, clouds...) and chat about them as you go along. If you don’t know the names of the trees, etc, look them up when you get home. Suddenly, a walk has become a science – or art – class.

2

Change your pace. For the highest cardio benefits, alternate 30 paces at a casual rate with 30 paces at speed. Keep it up for as long as you’re all comfortable, being sure to revert to the casual pace to steady your heart rate before stopping.

3

Keep quiet. Walking in silence is balm for the soul. Feel free to think, meditate or simply let your mind wander. Sometimes silence is the best way of appreciating and getting to know each other.

4

Bare your feet. Walking barefoot – particularly on uneven surfaces – allows for better control of your foot position when it strikes the ground, which leads to an improvement in balance and body awareness. It also helps develop better foot mechanics, which can lead to improved mechanics of the hips and knees, and builds stronger leg muscles.

5

Take a hike. While hiking is unlikely to be a daily event, even a monthly walk on the wild side will change the way you feel about the world. Clambering over rocks, helping each other down steep slopes and panting to the top of a hill makes us feel more connected to our environment – and ourselves.

Taking the power struggle out of screen management

We've all heard the horror stories, so what can we, as parents, do to keep our teenagers safe in cyberspace and on social media? **Pam Tudin**, co-founder of KLIKD and co-author of *Your Teen Unleashed!*, offers guidance

The solution lies in fostering connections with our teens, through openness and trust.

We do this through early open education, ongoing casual discussions around the dinner table and conscious, informed awareness of how our kids are doing in the digital world. It's important to establish that connection before making the rules.

Start talking to your tweens about device management and the Internet before you give them a phone or access to the digital world. Ask them what their friends are doing online, or what they think the older kids use it for. Get into their imaginations and belief systems. Above all, get to know *why* they so desperately want a phone/iPad/chromebook. Is it to make TikTok videos or play Fortnite (or other games)? Is it to be on a WhatsApp group with

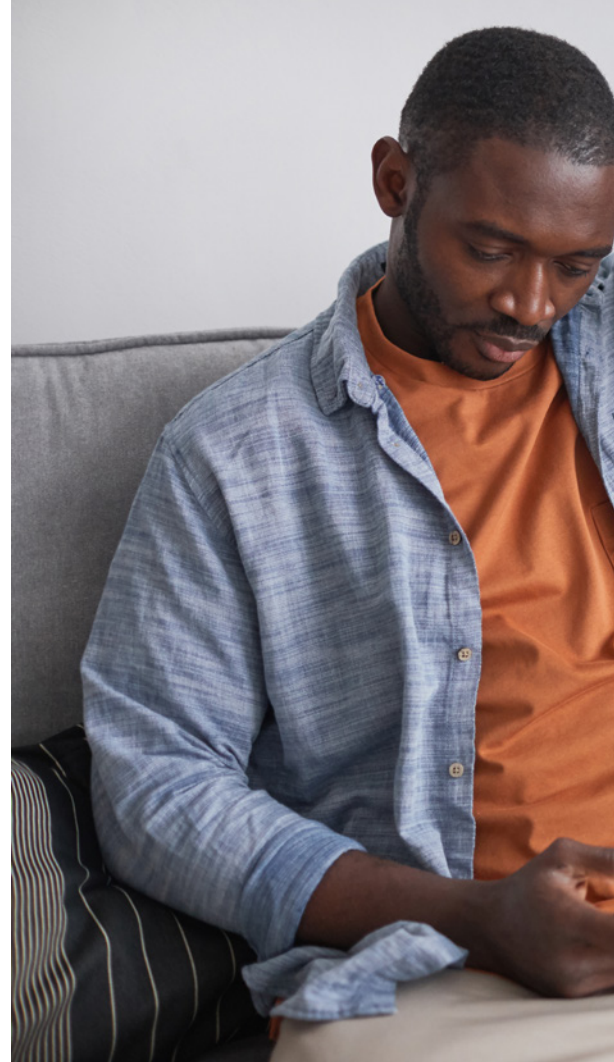
friends, or is it simply because all the cool kids have one? Give them examples of what might happen on a WhatsApp group (bullying, gaslighting, body-shaming, disclosing confidential information, etc). Ask them how they'd respond. Assess their maturity and coping level. Be honest about the risks of social media, without overwhelming them – and yourself – with the horror stories.

Remember that times have changed and our teens' life is vastly different from when we were young, so we must adjust. We must learn.

In KLIKD's free downloadable booklet, we provide you with

the guidelines for a social media contract for you and your child to sign. Yes, the differentiating factor lies in your teenager also getting a contract from you regarding *their* expectations of *you*. (Both the guidelines and contracts can be found at: <https://www.klikd.co.za/resources/>.) Discuss your hopes and expectations (not rules) with your child and the reasons for them. Make the contract your own. Add and amend the rules in a way that suits your family values and your expectations of your child.

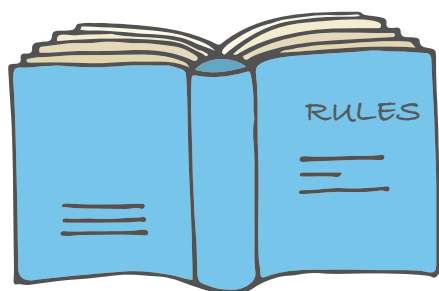
It's important to hold to who you are as a family. Your child might say something like: 'None of my friends' parents limit *their* time on social media/Fortnite.





Why are you doing this to me? It's not fair!' Don't be afraid to stand your ground. It's okay to say: 'We do things differently in our home. Other people's homes, their rules. Our home, our rules.'

You and your screenager both need to sign the contract. KLIKD's contract allows your child to know one really important thing: even if they mess up (and they will), you'll support them through their mistakes. The contract enables them to feel safe



'This ensures that you become their trusted person and prevents your child from going elsewhere to 'hide' the shame of what might have gone down online.'

coming to tell you about a mistake without your simply removing the phone as a hasty punishment. This ensures that you become their trusted person and prevents your child from going elsewhere to 'hide' the shame of what might have gone down online. There's always time for consequences. Be the safety net first.

As with your contract, KLIKD has provided a guideline for discussions with your teen too: real conversation-starters that take the power struggle out of contracting, kindly and fairly. Discuss the guidelines with your tween or teen and amend them to make them work for your family. It's recommended that both you and your tween and teen think through all the various possibilities before you hand over any device. However, if your child already has use of a phone or other device, it's never too late to lay down new rules – in fact, it's critical to do so because, in addition to the guidelines, as they get older, they may encounter new challenges online of which they need to be aware and for which they need to be prepared.

Forget the finger-wagging approach to screen management. Stop being the tyrant in your teen's life. Remember, this requires a 'we're in this together' approach, as opposed to an ongoing battle of wills.

First aid essentials

Of all the home must-haves, a properly stocked first aid kit should be at the top of your list. Fortunately, ready-made kits are available at places like Clicks and Dis-Chem. Just check that they have everything you need. Here's a handy list to get you started

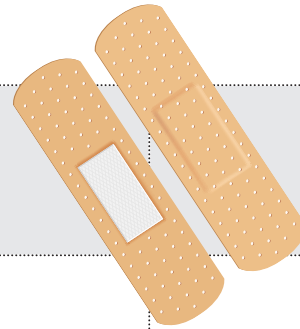
	Small burn-shields	Thermometer
	Latex or plastic gloves	Eyepads
	Sterile water ampoules	Arm sling 
	A small plastic glass or cup 	Packets of gauze
	Sharp scissors	First aid bandages (various sizes)
	Tweezers	Crêpe bandages (various sizes)
	Different-sized safety pins	Roll of plaster 





Box of multi-sized plasters	Paracetamol tablets
Reparil gel (for sunburn)	Sachet of GlucoGel
Rehidrat sachets	Box of antacids
Burnshield Hydrogel	Bactroban ointment
Antihistamine cream	SAFETY FIRST As with all things, a little knowledge can be dangerous thing and there's no point having a state-of-the-art first aid kit if you're not sure how to use it. The following organisations offer excellent courses to help ensure you'll know what to do if your child is injured or unwell: St John Ambulance Family First Aid Supernannies First Aid Training
Anti-bacterial cream	
Antihistamine eyedrops	
Anti-bacterial eyedrops	
Paracetamol syrup	

A list of emergency contact numbers (hospitals, poison centres, ambulances, your family doctor, etc)



On being heard

Phillip Doubell is the Interim Co-ordinator of the South African National Homeschooling Association (SANHSA). Here he explains his involvement with SANHSA, and the vital steps the organisation is taking to create harmony between you and the Department of Basic Education (DBE)



We started homeschooling three years ago and at this stage, we're homeschooling two of our girls, Chloé and Emily-Grace. Emily-Grace has special needs and she's The Boss of our home. We feel that home education provides her with the best environment to suit her needs. She's come a long way in her recovery and has baffled the medical profession with her development. The growth in Chloé since we started homeschooling is beautiful and exciting. She's become so confident and has blossomed into a maths whizz and aspires to becoming an architect.

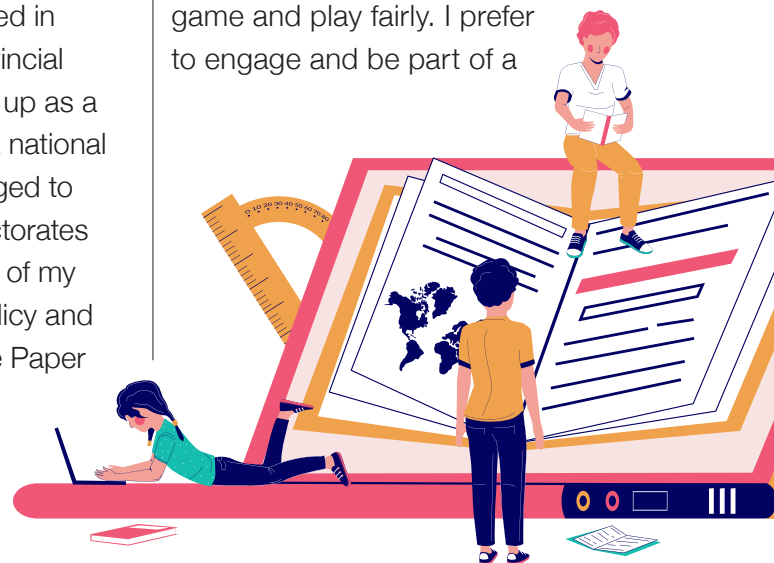
Homeschooling has changed me as a man and a father. It's given me a deeper relationship

with my family than I had before and changed my heart in many ways. My older children have also decided to home-educate and this is one of the reasons for my passion and drive to be part of the homeschooling movement: to take a stand for our children and for future generations of children.

I've worked within government for most of my life. I started in municipal, moved to provincial and subsequently ended up as a general manager within a national department. I was privileged to work within relevant directorates and branches where one of my functions was to draft policy and laws from Green to White Paper processes for approval within the legislature and Parliament. I later

resigned from national government and started my own consulting business, Oak Tree Corporation.

A maxim I live by is: 'Speak to people, not about them.' This is an ethic that guides my interactions with my family and neighbours, as well as my professional and community work. I don't sit on the bleachers jeering – I get in the game and play fairly. I prefer to engage and be part of a



solution, rather than remain on the fringes in opposition.

The formation of SANHSA

For years, we at the Eastern Cape Home Schooling Association (ECHSA) had the dream of creating a representative structure that would be able to bring the concerns of the homeschooling community straight to the ears of those who had the power to make a difference. Many homeschoolers from across South Africa have been in touch with us, asking to join us and lend their support to our efforts.

Last year, in October, that long-held aspiration came to fruition in SANHSA, an association run by homeschoolers, for homeschoolers, uniting all of us who love to educate our own children.

At this watershed time in South African homeschooling history, it's an honour to serve as Interim Co-ordinator, to advocate for the rights of those homeschoolers who haven't yet been born, but who'll be influenced and governed by the steps we take now.

Where are we concerning the policy?

When a policy is in the process of development, it goes through many stages. If you'd like to know more about the process, it's detailed on our website.



This policy had been in progress since 2014 and was approved in 2018. This means that the DBE won't accept any further comments on it, as the process of development has been concluded.

'A maxim I live by is "Speak to people, not about them".'

How to deal with policy development

1. Be part of the structures and part of the meetings when the policy's being discussed, thus engaging from the inside.
2. Take the policy to court to try to have it struck down if the engagement didn't yield the desired results.
3. Negotiate the best possible outcome for policy implementation if it can't be struck down in court.

At this moment, we're at Option 3. Unfortunately, there were no home education representatives present at the meetings when the policy was finalised, thus the outcome wasn't favourable to home educators and it hasn't been challenged in court. This means that the policy's here to stay unless someone takes it to court. So how does that play out for homeschoolers?



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Fatima Bham, a homeschooling mother and a graduate of the Harvard Law School, explains her own position: 'What are my options as a homeschooler? I can go underground and simply choose to homeschool illegally. I can go to court to challenge the current laws (but this route doesn't guarantee success and will be extremely expensive). Or I can engage with government. I can either attempt to convince the government to change the current laws and if that's unsuccessful, I can attempt to sway the interpretation of the current laws as much in my favour as I can. Engagement, to me, makes the most sense.' Bham's full article, *Concerning Registration*, can be read on the SANHSA website.

At SANHSA, we echo this sentiment of engagement and know that while we must stay within the confines of the policy, we can try to sway its interpretation.

The DBE has stressed that national government can't meet numerous small groups separately in order to iron out standard operating procedures that need to be filtered down to provincial level. Thus formal administrative representatives from homeschoolers is needed. As such, we launched SANHSA as that formal body of homeschoolers from all provinces to collaborate

in achieving the best possible interpretation of the policy.

Our strategy going forward

From my experience with government, I know that protocol is extremely important and the most effective way to advocate for our right to follow it and get into



'It's important for our movement to have policies and laws. This means that homeschooling is embedded in the structures of the country and can't be easily eradicated.'

the structure. We see SANHSA as a wedge and a funnel; first, we need to wedge the way open in these structures. Then we'll be able to funnel our collective concerns to create a safe space for our movement to flourish.

It's important for our movement to have policies and laws. This means that homeschooling is embedded in the structures of the country and can't be easily eradicated.

Making use of this opportunity to become a part of the DBE structure doesn't mean starting to work for the DBE or become 'registration agents'; rather, it means effecting change from the inside, creating a 'circle of safety' where we can all homeschool in peace.

We now have direct contact with key role-players within government. This has huge implications for us as a homeschooling community and as a nation. We can be heard. We can collaborate. We can educate government on what homeschooling is and the beautiful solution it offers for families on all socio-economic levels. We can make a real difference. Through your association, you can have a say and be heard. This is a watershed moment in the history of home education and something I'm very excited to be part of.

Please see the Summary of the Portfolio Committee Meeting concerning the aspects relating to homeschooling in the BELA Bill on our website.



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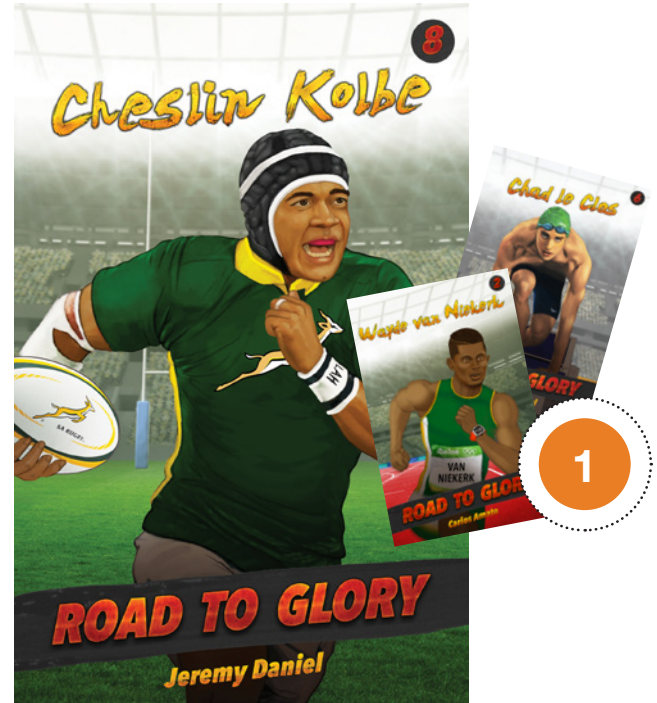
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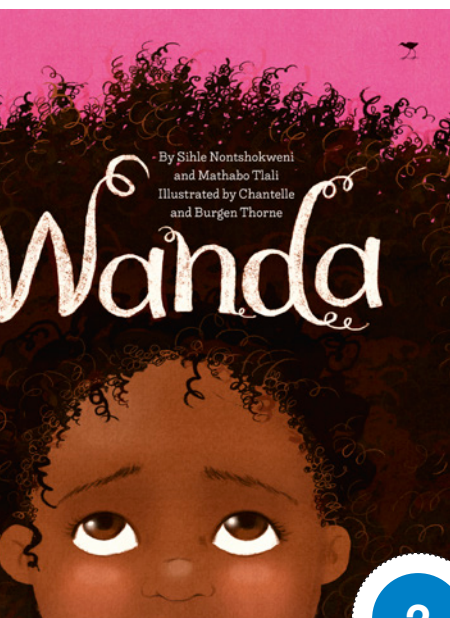
1. *Cheslin Kolbe* (Jonathan Ball)

Jeremy Daniel's *Road to Glory* series has taken sports-wild tweens and teens by storm, covering SA sporting legends as they strive to become national and international stars. *Cheslin Kolbe* is the eighth book in the series and tells the heart-warming tale of a kid from Kraaifontein, whose talent took him to international sports stardom, first to Toulouse, France and eventually to getting the call-up that would change his life forever: to play for the Springbok 2019 World Cup XV.

WIN! One lucky family can win all eight of the *Road to Glory* titles. Send us up to 20 words telling us why sport is so important to your child/children – along with a photo and name of your sporty tween or teen – and the best response will win. Email your entries to: sahomeschooling@isikhova.co.za, write **Road to Glory Win** in the subject line and include your cellphone number and physical address. (Please note that we reserve the right to publish the winning entry and photo in the next issue.) Entries close 25 April.

2. *Wanda* (Jacana)

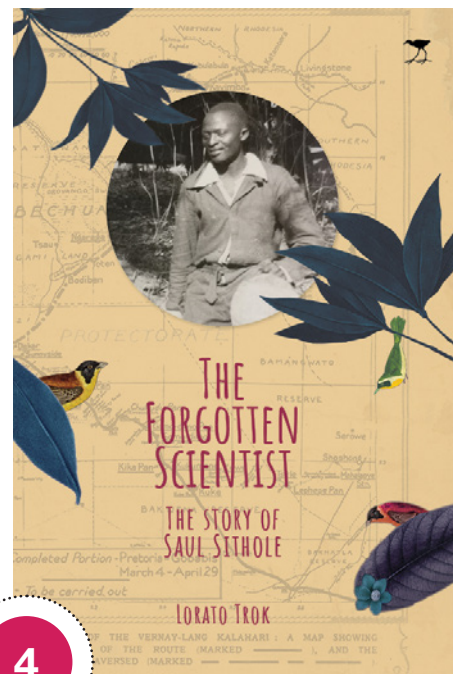
Your child will fall in love with Wanda, a brave and beautiful little girl with magnificent hair, who gets teased unmercifully by the boys at school. It's a story that starts with tears (you may even shed a couple yourself) and ends with Wanda learning about identity, cultural pride and acceptance of self through the wisdom of her grandmother, her *makhulu*. Written by Sihle Nontshokweni and Mathabo Tlali and exquisitely illustrated by Chantelle and Burgen Thorne.



2



3



4

WIN! Three lucky readers can each win a copy of this glorious book. Simply send your name, physical address and a photo and the name of your child to: sahomeschooling@isikhova.co.za and write **Wanda Win** in the subject line. (Please note that we reserve the right to publish the winning entries and photos in the next issue.) Entries close 25 April.

3. *When Morning Comes* (Jacana)

Teen dystopian fiction meets history in this fast-paced, superbly written adventure story by Arushi Raina. Zanele skips school and secretly plots against the apartheid

government. Only Thabo, schoolboy turned *tsotsi*, knows what she's up to. White suburban Jack is about to leave for varsity in his beat-up old Mustang; then he meets a girl. Shopkeeper's daughter Meena finds a packet of banned pamphlets that lead to a girl with a secret, a dangerous gangster and a boy with a Mustang. Everything changes. Unputdownable!

4. *The Forgotten Scientist: The Story of Saul Sithole* (Jacana)

If your child is inspired by natural history, social history, birding – or science of any kind, this little book will take them from 'I wish I could'

to 'I know I can'. Saul Sithole was a pioneering scientist who made an indelible contribution to anthropology and ornithology in this country, yet now is the first time he has been recognised for his 62 years of achievements. Clearly written by Lorato Trok and wonderfully illustrated with lovely old photographs.

All books are available at selected CNA stores and most online and local bookstores. Prices vary according to where you shop. Happy reading!

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'The more that you read, the more things you will know. The more that you learn, the more places you'll go.'

– Dr Seuss



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